

Running Head: MARGINALIZED VOICES

Exploring The Marginalized Voices of Birdwatching

Camryn Evans

University of Denver

— The Reason for the Research —

6:35pm. The last rays of the evening sun illuminate the Platte River — the river that will soon provide refuge for 600,000 Sandhill cranes as they rest on their long journey north. We gather on the bridge. Strangers yet family. Connected spiritually by our shared love for cranes that pulls us like magnets to this sacred location. And connected physically, each pair of our hands grasping the same ocular device that will allow us to be a part of something fascinating. The assembly holds its breath as the first bugle call reaches our ears, and 600,000 Sandhill cranes begin to speckle the horizon.

In April of 2023, I traveled to Kearney, Nebraska with my mom to witness an incredible natural phenomenon: the annual Sandhill crane migration. Every year, up to 600,000 migratory Sandhills fly in to roost along the Platte River, fueling up on Nebraska's many fields of waste grain before continuing the very long journey to their northern nesting grounds in the US, Canada, and even as far as Siberia. Witnessing this event felt extremely personal to me. Having spent nearly every moment of the previous six months performing the husbandry and health routines for all 15 of the world's crane species at the International Crane Foundation (ICF), I had gained a deeply intimate knowledge of nearly 100 individual cranes — their intelligence, their grace, their personal quirks and idiosyncrasies. To me, this avian mass above the Platte River was not *just* a flock of Sandhill cranes. It was a million Vincents, Starlords, and Rockets flying to me. Flying back to say, "Hello again, friend, and thank you for taking care of us."



A large flock of Sandhills gets ready to land on the Platte River.

Photograph: Cam Evans

600,000 Sandhill cranes now flood the evening sky, their sonorous, united call growing like an orchestra in permanent crescendo. I gaze through my binoculars as a tear silently slides down my cheek. "Here they come!" one birdwatcher exclaims to the rest of us, and we exchange looks of wild exhilaration. Most of the group is so astonished that we have completely lost our words. And while radically connected to these onlookers around me, I feel simultaneously set apart from them; my eyes scan the crowd of birdwatchers, and I notice that not one of them looks like me. Family yet strangers, we stand together on the bridge. A family, devoid of youth and color, witnessing the majesty of 600,000 Sandhill cranes.

As the mixed-race, Gen Z daughter of a white mom and a black dad, I began to wonder: Where are the young voices and the black voices in the world of birding? What is their contribution to the fight for ecological conservation that seems to be so comparatively underreported? With my special affinity for birds and their conservation, I was particularly curious to discover what ecological passions, involvement, and conservation efforts exist among the marginal population of birders like myself.

— Citizen Science Involvement —

While some very common motivations for birdwatching tend to be social or outdoorsy, yielding a leisurely birding experience, many individuals approach the hobby with the more quantitative, research-oriented purpose of assisting conservation efforts. (Benson, 2017, Larson et al., 2020, Sullivan et al., 2014). This interest in conservation urges many birdwatchers to do more than just watch birds; it motivates them to collect data in the name of science research, tracking things like behaviors, migration patterns, habitat usage, and species population among many other factors. Contributions like these are immensely helpful in the push for avian conservation, and it is important to understand how birdwatchers engage with this sector of the hobby. Little to no research exists, however, on this kind of involvement among younger generations and people of color in particular. Existing research on birdwatchers instead reflects primarily older, white voices (understandably so as this demographic accounts for the vast majority of the birdwatching population).

In speaking with other Gen Z birders as well as gathering data from both Gen Z and Millennial individuals, it quickly became apparent to me that while this kind of citizen science and conservation involvement might be spearheaded by older birders, it is championed and

propelled fervently by younger generations. A survey distributed across an array of online birding platforms reflects that 90.4% of its Gen Z and Millennial respondents are either actively involved or intending to become involved in citizen science, some of the most commonly shared citizen science efforts among these individuals being nest surveying, bird banding, behavioral monitoring, annual bird counts, and eBird contribution.

The eBird platform (like many digital platforms for environmental data collection) allows its global network of users to input data about bird distribution, abundance, and habitat usage to a central data repository, generating a wide pool of information that can be useful in many realms of formal scientific research. The output of data from eBird has grown significantly in recent years, notably among the scientific domains of ornithology, landscape ecology, computational sustainability, and conservation science, demonstrating just how useful citizen science can be in its augmenting of formal scientific research. What's more is that in addition to this significant output of data from eBird, the platform's input of data has grown tremendously as well, indicating a surge in user participation (Sullivan et al., 2014). It is quite reasonable to suppose that this recent surge of eBird participation can be attributed to younger generations; as we enter the world of birding, we are naturally beginning to discover some of the mechanisms and tools, like eBird, that often enhance the birding experience.

Carolina Wren (named so here for purposes of anonymity) is a strong, Gen Z proponent of citizen science projects like eBird. Not only does Wren contribute data to these platforms herself, but she also makes it a point to educate others about them, ultimately planting a seed that she hopes will encourage people to download apps like eBird. Wren says, "I don't care if they even report the birds— if they're just opening [the app] to find out what birds are around them, I'm excited. They're learning about what's around them, and that's sometimes just the first step of public outreach and education." Wren makes a relevant point about the educational benefit of citizen science platforms. A birder might contribute valuable data to eBird, but how

much greater an impact could that data have if it were recorded with others present, benefitting both scientists' research *and* non-birders' learning?

— The Importance of Environmental Education —

Wren notes that “...public outreach and education is so important for conservation, because...even if [people are] not contributing to citizen science and they’re just walking around with these apps on their phones, they’re still learning about the animals that need conservation.” This act of learning about threatened and endangered animals that Wren describes can be a very powerful contributor in the push for conservation. Studies show that individuals with greater knowledge of a species are more likely to donate to that species’ conservation fund than individuals with no knowledge of the species, indicating that degree of knowledge can generally predict conservation behavior (Lessard et al., 2018). Influencing public perceptions towards birds is evidently crucial in advancing avian conservation efforts; extending knowledge and awareness to the general public can ultimately ignite a widespread concern for protecting avian life where it has historically been disregarded (Benson, 2017, Lessard et al., 2018).

Of course a major barrier to this kind of widespread education is the issue of accessibility. We know that citizen science platforms like eBird (among many others) can be powerful tools in increasing public awareness about myriad species. But oftentimes, data collection platforms can be quite intimidating to navigate (much less to approach), especially for those less seasoned in the world of citizen science. Even Wren, someone considerably experienced in ecological work, admits, “I don’t use eBird very often because I don’t know how to use it very well, and it seems a little intimidating of an app.” I tend to have a similar experience as Wren. Sometimes I feel worried that I’m going to input the wrong information for the wrong region and ultimately skew data that could very well be exported for professional scientific research. This worry often prevents me from submitting the data altogether, and if data contribution can feel intimidating

to regular birders such as Wren and myself, it is not difficult to imagine that avian citizen science of any sort might feel completely unapproachable to the non-birding public.

One Gen Z survey respondent says that “[i]f a project is asking for data from just any citizen, it has to be simple for the citizens... There also needs to be someone accessible for the citizens to ask questions to and learn from. Collection of the data has to be very user-friendly to encourage more people to participate.” This sentiment is commonly shared among the respondents, indicating that many young birders recognize a need for greater accessibility in the world of citizen science, especially when considering how to best engage the general public.

Along with citizen science projects, educational outreach is a common and effective way to increase public knowledge, and subsequently, public engagement in conservation efforts. Environmental education initiatives are pertinent especially to birders who might have a stronger inclination towards the social sciences than they do the natural sciences, as educational outreach requires none of the data collection or field work commonly demanded by citizen science. Many Gen Z and Millennial individuals are engaged in this kind of initiative by leading birdwatching hikes and other environment-related field trips, as well as working on projects with the specific goal of kindling an appreciation for birds in other people. I participate in the latter, using my creative eye to generate avian artworks that I pair with important species facts and conservation status (information I already know, but that I hope plants a seed for my Instagram followers). My love for birds guides my paintbrush with ease. A piercing, golden crown, a pendant of rubies, and an icy, electric stare materialize on the page — just as beautiful two dimensionally as in the flesh. As the Grey Crowned Crane takes its form on my paper, I feel powerfully called to action, as I hope will be the case for those who encounter my infographics.



Grey Crowned Crane watercolor: Camryn Evans



Red Crowned Cranes watercolor: Camryn Evans



Blue Crane watercolor: Camryn Evans

Something quite special that I notice among the Gen Z and Millennial populations is that this educational effort exists not only in the context of inspiring non-birders, but between each other as well. Wren says, “I really do have to thank Peregrine Falcon [(a fellow ICF intern)], because...whenever I was with Falcon, I was in the deep end. [S]he will drive to a whole other

state just to see a rare bird, and it was very fascinating to be plunged into the deep end every time I was around her. And she always knew more about birds, and it really helped me become more curious than I already was about birds, because I wanted to be like her. I wanted to be like Falcon, where I could hear a bird and be like, ‘Yes, I know this bird’...” As Wren describes her admiration of Falcon, I can’t help but smile. Her words evoke a touching memory for me: snowy mornings, distant cranes greeting the day in their melodic language, and myself, rushing to the Crane Conservation Lab far behind the other interns, and cursing my chronic lateness as I frantically try not to slip on the road thick with ice. Amid my chaos, I look up. The other interns have already made it to the lab, but Wren is stopped in her tracks. *Is she alright?* As I make my way closer to Wren, I see that she is listening to and observing the songbirds in her vicinity. She does this so intently and for so long that I’m able to catch all the way up to her well before she finishes observing her birds. This quality of being present in the beauty of nature that Wren so often demonstrated during our time at ICF inspired me to download various bird identification apps, ultimately kindling the start of my own birdwatching journey. Having reflected on this memory, I come back to my conversation with Wren. “While you were looking up to and learning from Falcon at ICF, I was looking up to and learning from you,” I tell her. “A domino effect of inspiration and growth.”

This phenomenon of mutual inspiration is common within the young birding community, with one Gen Z birder sharing the following experience: “Being surrounded by 20+ bird nerds [at an Audubon camp] and being passionate and learning from each other drove my interest in birds into overdrive!” Educational inspiration of this sort — whether between birders and the general public, or between birders and other birders — is evidence of a thirst for learning that often spreads like wildfire through the young birdwatching community. What’s more, this eagerness to learn is entertained not only in casual, social settings, but in the more formal realm of academia as well, evidenced already by the Millennial generation and diligently continued by its Gen Z heirs.

— The Pursuit of Higher Education for Wildlife and the Environment —

My time at ICF truly solidified my desire to work with wildlife as a career, sparking my move across the country to an entirely new school for the Ecology & Biodiversity degree that will equip me with the skills necessary to address ecological concerns as they pertain to animal welfare. I was not surprised to find a considerable number of other Gen Z birders either actively pursuing or intending to pursue Bachelor's and/or Master's degrees in the ecological field, some with specializations in ornithology and wildlife biology.

With a Bachelor's degree in biology and a strong interest in wildlife-related graduate programs, Wren is an example of a Gen Z individual who is actively looking for opportunities in higher education that will allow her to gain specialized knowledge in some realm of wildlife biology. She says, "...I went to ICF and I worked with cranes and I was around Falcon and I was like, 'Okay, hang on. Damn it, birds are cool. I wish I knew more.'...[N]ow, when I'm looking for stuff like Master's programs, I'm leaning towards the ones that are working on birds, or reptiles and amphibians..." Peregrine Falcon herself is an aspiring ornithologist studying Wildlife Conservation at Unity College while also working as a field technician for the Florida Parks service. Once having completed her Bachelor's in Wildlife Conservation, Falcon intends to pursue a Master's degree so that she can begin working in an ornithology lab in the near future, stating, "...I base my career hopes around being able to work with birds. If it has nothing to do with birds, then I don't care about it." Mine, Wren's, and Falcon's trajectories serve as examples of how within Gen Z there is a passion for birds that often takes root in the hobby of birdwatching, extends into the pursuit of education, and culminates in one's career path, with all three of these contexts intertwining and supplementing each other along the way.

My collective findings demonstrate that young birders are enthusiastically dedicated to citizen science and public education initiatives, they support, inspire, and often help each other grow in the world of birding, and they showcase a sincere passion both for deepening their education in the ecological field as well as using that education to affect positive change in the world of conservation. This goes to illustrate that even though young birders make up a comparatively marginal sliver of the birding population, they possess just as strong a passion and just as promising an impact as those who've been in the hobby quite a bit longer.

In addressing the lack of youthful voices in birdwatching, it is important that I also confront the lack of racial diversity in the hobby; due to the intersectional nature of age and race, exploring one lends itself well to exploring the other. In keeping true to my experience as a black birder, the following exploration looks primarily into the black American experience. However, within this specific exploration of blackness, I occasionally use the encompassing term “people of color” when discussing general trends.

— Racial Disparities in the World of Birding —

It is no surprise that white people vastly outnumber people of color in the scene of outdoor recreation. This is hardly due to things like choice or values, though, as there are many rigid factors that have long had a hand in creating this vast disparity. For one, prolonged histories of legal disenfranchisement have created lasting income and housing inequalities that are still prevalent today. White folks have been building generational wealth in America for over 500 years now, while black folks have only had the opportunity to do so freely since 1965, thereupon commencing a grueling financial struggle for many black families which makes it difficult to spare income for things like binoculars or park tickets.

Not so easily captured by socio-economic statistics, however, is the legacy of generational trauma. We are the products of our past, and seeing our people brutally beaten and lynched in the woods has left succeeding generations of black folks with a pervading mistrust and unease in the outdoors. For so long, venturing outside the safety of your community was a death sentence for black people in America. Stay where you belong... stay out of the white man's path... stay *hidden*. This life-saving sentiment was instilled in every black American's psyche, conveyed to them tirelessly by their parents and passed down in the same manner to their children. And even when passing this sentiment verbally to black children was no longer as strong an imperative in the decades following the Civil Rights Movement, keeping to your community had been necessary for survival for *so long*— nearly four centuries — that it instinctively persisted even when lynching rates had finally trailed off in the 1960s. This is exhibited by J. Drew Lanham, a black ornithologist and professor of wildlife ecology whose advice for black birders in 2013 eerily echoes the above sentiment. “Carry your binoculars — and three forms of identification — at all times,” Lanham writes. “You’ll need the binoculars to pick that tufted duck out of the flock of scaup and ring-necks. You’ll need the photo ID to convince the cops, FBI, Homeland Security, and the flashlight-toting security guard that you’re not a terrorist or escaped convict.”

I see this generational trauma play out in my own family. My mom and I are big campers, and my dad, who truly loves nothing more than spending time with my mom and I, chooses never to join us on our camping trips. Running is also very central to my dad's life, his two locations for this hobby being the track at the high school where he teaches and the treadmill in our apartment's gym, but *never* a nature trail. Contrarily, my mom wouldn't ever choose a track or a treadmill over the beauty of a lush forest. Black, millennial journalist, Latria Graham, writes, “Vacations are meant to be methods of escapism. Believing this idyllic wilderness to be free of struggle, of complicated emotions, allows visitors to enjoy their day hikes” (2020). My mom is privileged to enjoy this idyllic, free-of-struggle wilderness that Graham describes, periodically fleeing to the mountains with abandon for a mental health reset. I am privileged to enjoy this

idyllic wilderness as well, but for me, enjoyment is often conditional; for my clarity and assurance, I need others to see me with my mom. *“Look, I’m with this nice, safe, white lady. It’s okay. No need to look at me twice,”* I say in my head as fellow hikers approach. Without my mom’s presence, however, I automatically craft an over-the-top performance of geniality to fellow hikers, worrying so extensively about how I’m perceived that I pay almost no mind to the flora and fauna that I had originally endeavored to see. *“Hello!” Was that ‘hello’ peppy enough?* *“My hike has been GREAT! Making my way up to mile 10 right now!” Can they tell that I’m a regular, experienced hiker? Or do I still appear out of place here?*

Clearly, this generational trauma has persisted beneath the surface for decades, but we are finally beginning to see it heal, and this is where the nexus between age and race in the world of birdwatching comes in. Of the total survey respondents (including all generations), 83.8% were white, with only 21 people of color out of the 130 who provided their race. What’s particularly interesting is that the Gen Z and Millennial populations account for 19 of these 21 people of color. It makes a lot of sense that as generations unfold, and as our social climate continues to become the most inclusive that it’s ever been, younger folks of color are beginning to participate in outdoor recreation at much higher rates than their parents and grandparents do.

There has also been a recent emergence of groups and events designed specifically to welcome people of color into outdoor recreation, such as black Birders Week, an annual, week-long series of online events highlighting the voices of black birders, and Outdoor Afro, an organization that serves to inspire black leadership in nature. I observed a similar group called Flock Together, a birdwatching initiative spearheaded by two young, black men that welcome dozens of birders of all backgrounds to experience the six Flock Together pillars: “building community, challenging perceptions, showing the benefits of nature, championing ecological protection, offering mental health support, and providing creative mentorship for the next generation”. While on a birdwatching hike, one Flock Together member addressed his fellow

birders with the following: “...please, when you leave today, know that nature is yours. It is your birthright. No one can tell you that this is not for you.” Evidenced by groups like Flock Together, there is a strong effort among young people today to mend the generational trauma that often tells us black folk to keep out of nature.

All of my findings indicate that not only are young birders enthusiastically involved in the fight for ecological conservation, but we are also beginning to showcase some of the first bits of generational healing among communities of color in America. With our devout engagement in conservation efforts as well as our avid championing of accessibility, us young birders are at the forefront of something so incredibly special: the welcoming of diversity into the world of birdwatching. Graham writes, “We’re no longer waiting for outdoors companies to find the budget for diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives. With the creation of a hashtag, a social media movement, suddenly we are hyper visible, proud, and unyielding” (2020). Graham plainly highlights the truth that younger generations are unsatisfied with the performative efforts of their predecessors, finally taking the fight both for ecological conservation and for justice into their own hands. As Flock Together’s final pillar suggests, this wholehearted effort of leadership and inclusivity by Gen Z and Millennial birders is meant to be instilled in the next generation, and as generational trends usually go, this colorful leadership will only strengthen as time goes on.

My own birdwatching journey has progressed significantly since its modest beginnings at ICF. With the conclusion of my internship there, my mom gifted me my very first camera in celebration of all of my hard work for the cranes, and shortly thereafter, I purchased a pair of binoculars. I was ready — the mysterious and majestic life of birds was within my reach! I set out with my camera, my binoculars, and my boundless enthusiasm, and the rest is history. Birdwatching hasn’t always been an easy or glamorous endeavor for me... it can be difficult to

Voices 15

find good birding spots, I often wind up braving the elements for hours on end, and as a type one diabetic, my pesky blood sugar alerts often interrupt my birding at the worst possible moments (did it really have to beep right when I was about to . But at the end of the day, my love for birds pushes me forward every time. I'm young, I'm black, and I'm proud of my evolution and persistence in this often monolithic community.

I would now like to share a few visual snippets of this magical, challenging, rewarding birdwatching journey of mine. The following are some of the amateur photographs that I'm proudest of:



A mother Robin hard at work foraging for her hungry triplets. Dad is nearby guarding the nest!





This pair of Ospreys definitely won the staring contest!



A sleepy Burrowing Owl tries



Voices 17

(and fails) to awaken for his
close-up.



A flock of Sandhill cranes meet up with
their travelling friends in a corn field.



Preparing for landing!

A curious Sandhill cocks its head at my camera.



A frisky Sandhill begins to dance.



And off they go on their migration north!
Bibliography

- Benson, E. S. (2017). A centrifuge of calculation: Managing data and enthusiasm in early twentieth-century bird banding. *Osiris*, 32, 286–306. DOI:10.1086/694172
- Graham, L. (2020). Out there, nobody can hear you scream. *Outside Magazine*. Retrieved from <https://www.outsideonline.com/culture/essays-culture/out-there-nobody-can-hear-you-scream>
- Lanham, J. D. (2013). 9 Rules for the black birdwatcher. *Orion Magazine*. Retrieved from <https://orionmagazine.org/article/9-rules-for-the-black-birdwatcher>
- Larson, L., Cooper, C., Futch, S., Singh, D., Shipley, N., Dale K., LeBaron, G., Takekawa, J. (2020). The diverse motivations of citizen scientists: Does conservation emphasis grow as volunteer participation progresses?. *Biological Conservation*. 242. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2020.108428>
- Lessard, S., Morse, W., Lepczyk, C., Seekamp A. (2018). Perceptions of Whooping Cranes among waterfowl hunters in Alabama: Using specialization, awareness, knowledge, and attitudes to understand conservation behavior. *Human Dimensions of Wildlife*, 23(3), 227-241. DOI:10.1080/10871209.2017.1414335
- Sullivan, B. L., Aycrigg, J. L., Barry, J. H., Bonney, R. E., Bruns, N., Cooper, C. B., Damoulas, T. A., Dhondt, A., Deitterich, T., Farnsworth, A., Fink, D., Fitzpatrick, J. W., Fredericks, T., Gerbracht, J., Gomes, C., Hochachka, W. M., Iliff, M. J., Lagoze, C., La Sorte, F. A., Merrifield, M., Morris, W., Phillips, T. B., Reynolds, M., Rodewald, A. D., Rosenberg, K. V., Trautmann, N. M., Wiggins, A., Winkler, D. W., Wong, W., Wood, C. L., Yu, J., Kelling, S. (2014). The eBird

enterprise: An integrated approach to development and application of citizen science.

Biological Conservation. 169, 31-40. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2013.11.003>